

Solution to import dependence on vegetable oil does not lie in hiking MSP

India's pulses and vegetable oil imports **touched** a record 7.3 million tonnes (mt) and 16.4 mt, valued at \$5.5 billion and \$17.3 billion respectively, in 2024-25. Some of that may have had to do with the strong **El Niño-induced drought** of 2023-24, whose effects on food inflation extended right up to December 2024. It forced **large-scale** imports — in the case of pulses, from an average of 2.6 million during 2018-19 to 2022-23 to 4.7 mt and 7.3 mt in the **following** two **fiscals**. But the same cannot be said about vegetable oil imports, which have more than doubled from 7.9 mt in 2013-14. It's quite possible that pulses imports will reduce **considerably** in the current fiscal, assuming a normal monsoon. But that's **unlikely** with vegetable oils, where rising imports have **attained** a structural **inevitability** similar to petroleum crude and natural gas.

In pulses, scientists have **bred** shorter-duration chana (chickpea) and photo-thermo insensitive moong (green gram) varieties, enabling farmers to grow these with **minimal irrigation** or in all four seasons. **Much** of the increased domestic pulses production after 2015-16, **notwithstanding** the **setbacks** of the last two years, **has** been **courtesy of** chana and moong. It has, then, limited the need for imports mainly to arhar (pigeon-pea) and urad (black gram): In a normal year, India can produce roughly 90 per cent of its consumption requirement. Such effort has been **woefully** lacking in oilseeds. Take soyabean, where the average per-hectare **yield** in India is hardly one tonne, compared to 2.6 tonnes in Argentina and 3.4-3.5 tonnes in Brazil and the US. Not **allowing** genetic modification in soyabean or mustard, with **potential** for raising yields, **hasn't** helped either. It's not surprising that the import dependence in vegetable oils is well over 60 per cent — and, at the current **pace**, set to rise further.



The solution does not **lie** in hiking minimum support prices (MSP). MSPs have no meaning unless **accompanied** by physical **procurement** as with rice and wheat. But even that has **limitations**. The latest **MSP** for soyabean, at Rs 5,328 per quintal or \$615 per tonne, **is** way above the **landed cost** of \$400-450 for the same from Brazil and the US. What the government can do is to **assure** oilseeds and pulses farmers of a minimum income support, while setting this at a **reasonable** level that **incentivises** them to grow and even expand **acreages** under these crops. But there is no **substitute ultimately** for increasing yields and reducing cultivation costs — which has unfortunately not happened in oilseeds, **unlike** with rice, wheat or sugarcane.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

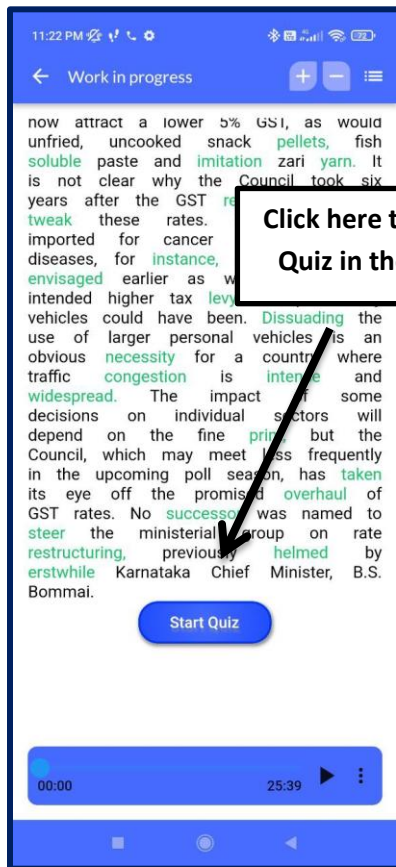
1. **Lie** (verb) – rest, reside, exist, depend, be located आधारित होना
2. **Touch** (verb) – reach, hit, amount to, attain, arrive at पहुँचना
3. **El Niño** (noun) – a warming of the ocean surface, or above-average sea surface temperatures, in the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean. एल नीनो (प्रशांत महासागर में तापमान वृद्धि का एक मौसमी प्रभाव)
4. **Induced** (adjective) – caused, triggered, brought about, stimulated, generated प्रेरित
5. **Drought** (noun) – dry spell, water shortage, aridity, rain deficit, desiccation सूखा
6. **Large-scale** (adjective) – extensive, widespread, massive, comprehensive, broad बड़े पैमाने पर
7. **Following** (adjective) – subsequent, next, ensuing, succeeding, later बाद का
8. **Fiscal** (noun) – financial year, budget period, accounting year, tax year, economic cycle वित्तीय वर्ष
9. **Considerably** (adverb) – significantly, notably, substantially, appreciably, markedly काफी हद तक
10. **Unlikely** (adjective) – improbable, doubtful, uncertain, questionable, implausible असंभव
11. **Attain** (verb) – achieve, reach, accomplish, secure, obtain प्राप्त करना
12. **Inevitability** (noun) – certainty, unavailability, fate, necessity, preordainment अनिवार्यता
13. **Breed** (verb) – develop, cultivate, generate, produce, engineer उत्पन्न करना
14. **Minimal** (adjective) – least, negligible, smallest, nominal, meager न्यूनतम
15. **Irrigation** (noun) – watering, farming supply, agricultural hydration, moisture supply, sprinkling सिंचाई
16. **Notwithstanding** (preposition) – despite, although, even though, in spite of, regardless of के बावजूद
17. **Setback** (noun) – hindrance, obstacle, failure, delay, blow रुकावट / झटका
18. **Courtesy of** (phrase) – due to, because of, thanks to, as a result of, owing to के कारण
19. **Woefully** (adverb) – sadly, badly, unfortunately, pitifully, lamentably अत्यंत दुखद रूप से
20. **Yield** (noun) – output, harvest, production, crop, return उपज / उत्पादन

21. **Potential** (noun) – capability, possibility, capacity, promise, likelihood संभाव्यता
22. **Pace** (noun) – speed, rate, tempo, velocity, momentum गति
23. **Lie** (verb) – reside, rest, exist, be found, be placed स्थित होना
24. **Accompany** (verb) – go with, attend, follow, coincide with, be associated with साथ होना
25. **Procurement** (noun) – purchase, acquisition, sourcing, obtaining, buying क्रय / खरीद
26. **Limitation** (noun) – restriction, constraint, drawback, shortcoming, obstacle सीमा
27. **Landed cost** (noun) – total cost, import price, final price, all-inclusive price, delivery cost कुल लागत (आयात की गई वस्तु की)
28. **Assure** (verb) – guarantee, promise, ensure, secure, affirm आश्वासन देना
29. **Reasonable** (adjective) – fair, just, moderate, sensible, acceptable उचित
30. **Incentivise** (verb) – motivate, encourage, induce, stimulate, promote प्रोत्साहित करना
31. **Acreage** (noun) – land area, farmland, cultivated area, estate size, agricultural tract भूमि क्षेत्र
32. **Substitute** (noun) – replacement, alternative, option, proxy, stand-in विकल्प
33. **Ultimately** (adverb) – eventually, finally, in the end, at last, at the conclusion अंततः
34. **Unlike** (preposition) – different from, in contrast to, dissimilar to, as opposed to, not like इसके विपरीत

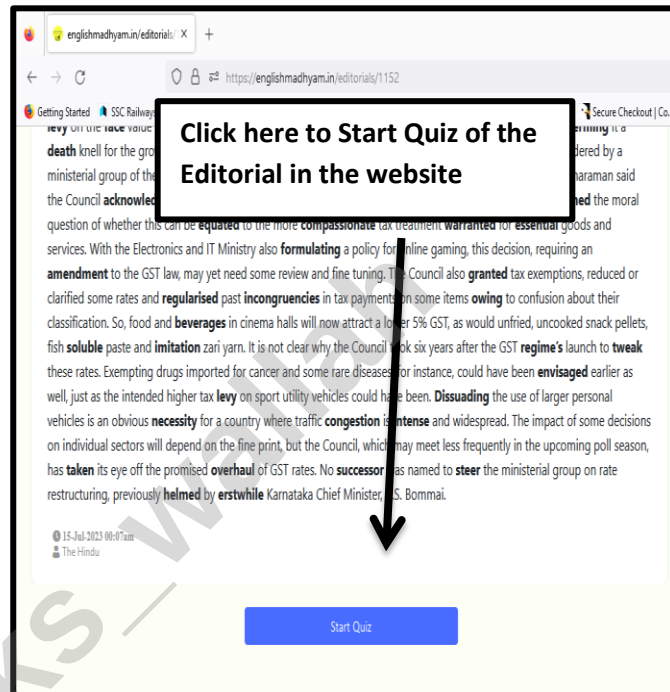
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Record Imports:** In 2024–25, India imported 7.3 million tonnes of pulses and 16.4 million tonnes of vegetable oil, worth \$5.5 billion and \$17.3 billion respectively.
2. **Drought Impact:** The El Niño-induced drought of 2023–24 increased food inflation and forced higher pulse imports temporarily.
3. **Pulses Outlook:** Assuming normal monsoons, pulse imports are expected to reduce as India can meet about 90% of its domestic requirement in normal years.
4. **Vegetable Oil Challenge:** Unlike pulses, vegetable oil imports show a structural rise and resemble dependence on crude oil and natural gas.
5. **Pulses R&D Success:** Scientists developed shorter-duration and climate-resilient varieties of chana and moong, boosting domestic production.
6. **Targeted Shortfall in Pulses:** Imports are now largely limited to arhar and urad, unlike in earlier years.
7. **Oilseeds Neglect:** Comparable scientific effort and innovation have been lacking in oilseeds cultivation.
8. **Low Soyabean Yields:** India's soyabean yield (~1 tonne/hectare) lags behind global leaders like Brazil (3.5 t/ha) and Argentina (2.6 t/ha).
9. **No GM Policy:** India's restriction on genetically modified soyabean and mustard limits potential yield improvements.
10. **High Import Dependency:** India depends on imports for over 60% of its vegetable oil needs — a figure likely to rise.
11. **Ineffectiveness of MSP:** Merely raising the Minimum Support Price does not help unless backed by large-scale procurement.
12. **Global Price Gap:** India's MSP for soyabean (\$615/tonne) is significantly higher than the global landed cost (\$400–450/tonne).
13. **Viable Alternative:** The editorial suggests income support schemes instead of price support (MSP) to encourage cultivation of oilseeds and pulses.
14. **Yield Improvement Essential:** Long-term reduction in import dependence requires increased crop productivity and lower production costs.
15. **Learning from Other Crops:** Unlike rice, wheat, and sugarcane, oilseeds have not benefited from technological or institutional support to raise yields.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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